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A FLASHY LAWYER FOR OSWALD'S KILLER

by RICHARD WARREN LEWIS photographers JACK FIELDS/ANDY HANSON

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When Dallas nightclub operator Jack Ruby burst through police lines to shoot down Lee Harvey Oswald, the alleged assassin of President John F. Kennedy, he did what no man has every done before. He killed a man in the sight of millions of witnesses on television.

All across the country, twice-stunned Americans wondered what defense Ruby would or could make -- and who would conduct that defense. So did Ruby's family. His relatives sifted through dozens of applications and recommendations before making their choice: Melvin Houston Belli (pronounced BELI-eye) -- one of the most successful, most controversial and most flamboyant of present-day trial lawyers.

Although he has defended a score of murderers in the past ten years -- successfully in all but two cases -- Belli is best known for his prowess in cases involving personal injury, a field in which he is widely regarded as preeminent. On over 100 occasions he has won his clients awards of more than \$100,000 -- sometimes much more -- and he is understandably unpopular with insurance companies, which have to pay these awards.

Some insurance men, in fact, feel that Belli, more than any other individual, is responsible for the sharp increase in liability-insurance rates during recent years. But Belli's detractors are not confined to the world of insurance. A second major group which feels no affection for him is the medical profession. In both personal-injury and malpractice cases -- another Belli specialty -- doctors frequently face him as witnesses called by the defense. "He's the type of man who, in cross-examination, tends to intimidate people," says Dr. Eugene Hoffman, a member of the house of delegates of the American Medical Association. "If a lawyer can upset an expert witness by making him contradict himself or answer questions partially or lose his temper, the expert is no good. Doctors don't like to be halted any more than anyone else."

But Belli is not a man to be intimidated. In fact, he is a man who has found his own way to the courtroom. Probably the most spectacular of Belli's exhibitions in his costume of celebrating court

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